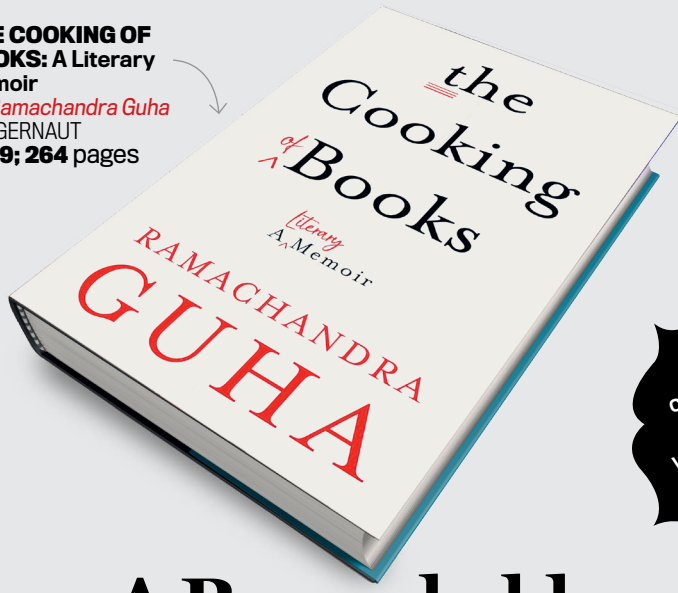
THE COOKING OF BOOKS: A Literary Memoir
by Ramachandra Guha
JUGGERNAUT
₹**699; 264** pages



BOOKS

A Remarkable Friendship

A chronicle of Ramachandra Guha's rewarding—and eccentric—relationship with his long-time editor, Rukun Advani

The book contains many delightfully wicked asides on academic trends and fashions

rare, in fact rarer than good writers." Far too often, when acknowledged, it is for their role in improving the language and, sometimes, the structure of the text. Their role in the shaping of ideas and arguments, including by pointing authors to other texts that they may profit from, is uncommon. So, when Ram Guha writes, "In an author's life, the person next in importance to his or her romantic partner is his or her editor", he is foregrounding the 'unacknowledged' in the world of publishing.

The story of how Ram Guha and his editor Rukun Advani came together goes beyond "an author's tribute to the remarkable (and remarkably self-effacing) editor who made his books possible". It permits the reader to enter into the process of how drafts are transformed into finished products, as also the investment, both intellectual and emotional, that such collaborative ventures demand. Far too often, differences between authors and editors turn into disagreements, making subsequent collaborations rare. To have worked together over decades tells us something not only about Ram and Rukun, but also how differences in style and temperament can be modulated by shared values and interests (and sufficient distance). And, more, respect for what each brings to the table.

Beyond an ode to friendship, the exchanges between the author and editor "provide insights not merely into book history and the culture of polishing, but also into the social and intellectual history of their time", at least in the English language. There are many delightfully wicked asides on academic trends and fashions, how innovative and creative initiatives like Subaltern Studies were transformed by the new woke and identarian orthodoxies in western academia, much to their detriment.

It is more difficult in today's climes to ignore the crassness that has crept into all spheres of life, not just the world of books and ideas. Money/success/visibility are, after all, the new measures of worth. But nostalgia about an imagined, more idyllic past, as so many Nehruvian liberals, more so from relatively privileged classes, are prone to have, is a serious misreading of both our past and present. Equally disconcerting is the tendency to elevate one's world of friends, colleagues, compatriots to a position of centrality disregarding other publishers/editors who made signal contributions to the world of ideas. Such lapses detract from what otherwise is a highly readable and insightful text. ■

–Harsh Sethi

BOOKS

THE BOOK SELLER

Rajen Mehra's *Never Out of Print* recounts the fascinating journey of Rupa Publishers

The publishing behemoth Rupa began life on a pavement in Calcutta in 1936 when Daudayal Mehra, the author's enterprising grand-uncle, decided to sell books for a living. From those humble beginnings, it evolved into a leading distributor of English-language trade books, before wading into publishing. The first book Rupa ever published was the Indian edition of Hermann Hesse's *Siddhartha*.

The publisher was buoyed by several good bets, writers like Sunil Gavaskar, Ruskin Bond and Chetan Bhagat. From presidents to politicians, literary giants to towering industrialists, everyone's written for, or been written about, at Rupa.

The book also doubles up as an autobiography of Mehra, under whose watch Rupa has really thrived, and has everything from a nostalgic trip to Pakistan to regular meetings with Nepal PM G.P. Koirala, and 'liquid lunches' with M.L. Jaisimha in Hyderabad (with the other cricket legend, Salim Durani, racing Mehra to the airport for the flight home when these lunches went on for too long).

Never Out of Print is rich in detail—perhaps too much so. But it's rescued by interesting nuggets. Did you know, for instance, that the company's first colophon was designed by Satyajit Ray? The rare visuals from the author's archives—like Sunil Gavaskar's handwritten manuscript of *Sunny Days*, a Rupa bestseller—are an absolute treat.

Of course, it's a hagiography, but Rupa seems to have been run on the principles of hard work and a level playing field. (The author's first day at work had him sweeping the floor and dusting the books.) It's also an ode to the last mile of the book business—the bookseller—and Mehra individually identifies a galaxy of them. ■

–Amit Dixit